



**moral
realism**



**moral
nihilism**



**moral
relativism**

On either interpretation, the emotivist might reasonably claim to have an advantage over the relativist in explaining what's going on in cases of moral disagreement. According to the emotivist, it is like one of the following kinds of disagreement:

“Study hard tonight!”

“Don’t study hard tonight, watch TV instead!”

‘‘Boo, Notre Dame!’’

‘‘Yay, Notre Dame!’’

Both seem like genuine varieties of disagreement — but
neither is disagreement about the facts.

This means that disagreements about morality are not
factual disagreements. Is this plausible?

Emotivists think that it is, and that it can explain the nature of moral disagreement. Moral disagreements can seem **intractable** in a way that factual disagreements don't. This might be explained by the idea that there are not really any facts over which the disputants disagree.

Note that the emotivist can think that arguments about morality involve some arguments about facts. Consider, for example, two people who disagree about the morality of abortion. They might argue about whether a fetus at 3 months has sensations, and they might argue about the effects of abortion or unwanted pregnancies on women.

These are factual disagreements.

But notice that they might reach a point at which they agree on all of the relevant facts and **still** disagree about whether abortion is morally permissible. At this point, the emotivist says, the disagreement is just about preferences or feelings, not facts.

disagreement. According to the enthusiast, it is like one of

explaining what's going on in cases of moral

On this interpretation, the emotivist might reasonably

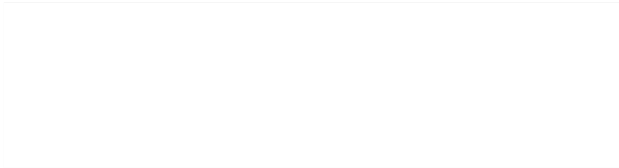
the following kinds of disagreement:

claim to have an advantage over the relativist in



'Study hard tonight!'

‘Don’t study hard tonight, watch TV instead!’



‘Boo, Notre Dame!’

‘Yay, Notre Dame!’

neither is disagreement about the facts.

Both seem like genuine varieties of disagreement — but

factually disagreements. Is this plausible?

This means that disagreements about morality are not

Enotivists think that it is, and that it can explain the

not really any facts over which the disputants disagree.

seemingly intractable in a way that fuels disagreements

nature of moral disagreement. Moral disagreements can

don't. This might be explained by the idea that there are

of abortion. They might argue about whether a fetus at 3

Note that the minimalist can think that arguments about

morality involve some arguments about facts. Consider,

for example, two people who disagree about the morality

months has sensitised them, and they might argue about the

effects of abortion on unwanted pregnancies on women.

These are factual disagreements.

agree on all of the relevant facts and still disagree about

But notice that they might reach a point at which they

whether abortion is morally permissible. At this point, the

environmentalist says, the disagreement is just about preferences

or feelings, not facts.